

UPSC Civil Services (Main) Simulation GS-I

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

Q1. Explain how a river's energy-load relation creates a sequence of erosional and depositional landforms.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (123 words; practice model, not official): Fluvial form follows changing energy relative to load, modified by rock, discharge, base level and tectonic or human interruption. Running water erodes by hydraulic action, corrosion or abrasion, attrition and solution; it transports load by traction, saltation, suspension and solution before deposition when competence falls. A graded river tends toward a concave-up long profile in dynamic balance with discharge, sediment load, rock resistance and base level; uplift, floods and dams can interrupt the tendency. Steep gradients favour vertical incision, V-shaped valleys, gorges, rapids, waterfalls and interlocking spurs, but local rock and discharge matter more than a rigid stage label. Helicoidal flow links outer-bank erosion to inner-bank deposition; neck cutoff can form an ox-bow lake, while repeated overbank deposition builds floodplains and natural levees.

Q2. Differentiate the principal erosional and depositional landforms of valley glaciation.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (97 words; practice model, not official): Agent, process, form and sediment sorting distinguish plucking-abrasion landforms from till and meltwater deposits. Plucking detaches jointed blocks and abrasion by entrained debris polishes, striates and grinds bedrock, producing rock flour and asymmetric roche moutonnée forms. Cirques, aretes and horns develop around glacier heads; valley ice widens and deepens V-valleys into U-shaped troughs and leaves hanging tributary valleys. Direct ice deposition is generally unsorted till; lateral, medial, terminal and ground moraines describe debris position or form. Eskers are sinuous ridges deposited by subglacial or englacial streams, while outwash plains contain relatively sorted sediment spread by braided meltwater.

Q3. Explain the demographic transition model and identify why the growth spurt appears in the middle stages.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (122 words; practice model, not official): The demographic transition model is driven by mortality decline preceding fertility decline; the temporary gap between the two rates creates rapid population growth before stability returns. Growth rate, crude birth rate, crude death rate, total fertility rate, infant mortality rate, life expectancy and sex ratio are the standard population indicators. In demographic transition the death rate usually falls before the birth rate, so the gap between them produces the growth spurt. Stage 1 has high birth and high death rates with fluctuating growth, while Stage 2 keeps birth rates high but mortality falls rapidly. Stage 3 brings fertility decline, Stage 4 has low birth and death rates with stable growth, and Stage 5 in some advanced societies means below-replacement fertility and ageing.

Q4. Discuss what makes Indian society unique in sustaining its culture.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (111 words; practice model, not official): Indian culture persisted through accommodative absorption and institutional recognition rather than insulation, carried by decentralised transmission and syncretic idioms, while hierarchy survived inside the same continuity. Indian diversity runs along ethnic or ethno-linguistic, linguistic, religious, regional and caste-tribe axes that are layered and overlapping rather than parallel, so cohesion depends on whether the axes reinforce each other or cut across each other. Sufi dargahs, Bhakti saint-poets, shared local deities and regional festivals such as Onam, Bihu and Pongal create composite belonging that crosses religion and region. Common schools, markets, elections and public transport work as routine integrative spaces in which diverse groups interact, and internal migration for work normalises mixed neighbourhoods.

Q5. Distinguish Sanskritisation from Westernisation with Indian examples.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (110 words; practice model, not official): Sanskritisation is upward emulation inside an existing local hierarchy while Westernisation introduces new values that can subvert that hierarchy, so the two processes can coexist in one community without being the same thing. M.N. Srinivas's Sanskritisation is the process by which a lower or middle caste adopts the dietary, ritual and marriage practices of a locally higher-status caste to claim higher local status; it is a claim to mobility rather than proof that acceptance or material mobility follows. Srinivas's Westernisation is change arising from sustained contact with Western, particularly British, values, technology and institutions, introducing new values such as equality and rationality instead of emulating an existing

local hierarchy.

Q6. What changed and what continued under the Government of India Act 1858?

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (99 words; practice model, not official): Sovereignty and the London control chain changed, while the local coercive and revenue machinery largely continued. The Government of India Act 1858 ended Company rule and abolished the Board of Control. A British Cabinet minister, the Secretary of State for India controlled Indian affairs from London. The Secretary of State was assisted by a fifteen-member Council of India. The Governor-General also became the Crown's Viceroy, and Canning was the first Viceroy. Crown rule tied Indian administration more directly to British Cabinet, parliamentary and imperial strategy. The collector, police, courts and revenue priorities survived the transfer from Company to Crown.

Q7. Compare Gandhi's roles in the Ahmedabad and Kheda struggles of 1918.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (116 words; practice model, not official): Ahmedabad tested mediation, worker discipline, fasting and arbitration in an industrial dispute; Kheda tested organised revenue refusal and regional cadre leadership against the state. In the 1918 Ahmedabad plague-bonus dispute, workers initially sought 50%, owners offered 20%, and Gandhi supported a 35% wage increase. Anasuya Sarabhai supported the workers, while her brother Ambalal Sarabhai was a leading mill owner and Gandhi's associate. After a twenty-one-day strike, Gandhi's three-day fast, his first in an Indian struggle, reinforced the pledge and pressed the dispute toward arbitration; sources differ on the final percentage outcome. The 1918 Kheda campaign sought suspension of land revenue where assessed produce was four annas or less, one-quarter of normal, under the government's own rules.

Q8. Explain why the Instrument of Accession initially demanded only three subjects from acceding states.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (112 words; practice model, not official): The instrument's narrowness was its strength: by asking only for Defence, External Affairs and Communications it demanded exactly what no state could supply for itself, which made acceptance cheap in appearance and decisive in substance. The Instrument of Accession asked acceding states to transfer only three subjects - Defence, External Affairs and Communications - a deliberately narrow demand that covered precisely what no princely state could exercise for itself while leaving internal administration untouched for the moment. Every state except Junagadh, Jammu and Kashmir and Hyderabad had acceded to India by 15 August 1947, so the three famous crisis cases were exceptions inside an overwhelmingly successful negotiation and not the normal pattern of accession.

Q9. Distinguish Khajuraho and Odisha as two mature Nagara solutions.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (133 words; practice model, not official): Khajuraho and Odisha both belong to the Nagara family, but they solve temple form differently. Khajuraho temples usually stand on high jagati terraces without enclosure walls, and their connected halls lead into a clustered shikhara composition integrated with dense sculpture. Odisha temples, by contrast, are better introduced through the rekha deul sanctum and pidha deul hall within a more enclosure-conscious Kalinga complex. Their exteriors are richly articulated, but the regional vocabulary of deul types itself becomes more explicit. The comparison matters because it prevents Nagara from becoming one undifferentiated box. Khajuraho is the best case for sculpture-and-wall integration in an open terrace setting. Odisha is the best case for a region where sanctum and hall types are formally distinguished and where monuments such as Lingaraja, Mukteswara and Konark establish a different mature line.

Q10. How did Enlightenment thought challenge arbitrary political authority?

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (99 words; practice model, not official): It replaced inherited authority with tests of rights, consent, institutional limitation and public reason, while stopping short of modern universal democracy. John Locke's 1689 rights-and-government formulation linked natural rights, consent and limited government, making resistance to rights-violating rule politically defensible. Montesquieu's 1748 institutional argument connected constitutionalism with separation of powers as a restraint on arbitrary authority. Rousseau's 1762 social-contract argument placed popular sovereignty in the people, while its general-will logic also carried a possible coercive edge. Voltaire's critique of clerical authority elevated reason over dogma and widened secular public debate, but anti-clericalism must not be equated automatically with democracy.

Q11. Distinguish weathering, erosion and mass movement. Show how their interaction can create risk along a Himalayan road corridor.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (127 words; practice model, not official): Weathering breaks or alters rock in situ; erosion detaches and transports material through water, wind, ice or waves; mass movement transfers rock/debris downslope mainly under gravity. In a Himalayan road corridor, fractured rock and weathered regolith provide susceptible material. A road cut may steepen or undercut the slope and redirect drainage. Intense rain can infiltrate joints, add weight and raise pore-water pressure until resisting strength is exceeded. The resulting slide blocks the road; runoff may then entrain debris and erode the toe. GSI inventory/susceptibility work shows why geology, slope, rainfall and exposure must be combined. Yet neither road construction nor rainfall alone proves cause at a particular site. Site investigation, drainage design, toe support, slope treatment, spoil control, maintenance and warning/closure protocols are needed.

Q12. Compare global savanna with India's deciduous, thorn and grassland analogues.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (158 words; practice model, not official): Both reflect wet-dry seasonality, but India's forest and grassland mosaics differ by monsoon, soil, hydrology and management history. India has wet-dry tropical environments and savanna-like mosaics, but a more precise comparison uses deciduous forest, thorn scrub and grasslands rather than proof that India is one homogeneous Sudan climate. Indian source notes associate tropical moist deciduous forest broadly with about 100 to 200 centimetres of rainfall, with teak prominent in many peninsular belts and sal in many northern and eastern belts. Dry deciduous forests occupy drier monsoon interiors and shed leaves to reduce dry-season water loss; rainfall thresholds overlap regionally and should not be treated as exact national walls. Tropical thorn forest and scrub reflect climatic aridity interacting with grazing and cutting, grading through north-western and interior semi-arid belts; they are not invariably degraded moist forest. Terai tall grasslands, shola grassland-forest mosaics and Banni's arid-saline grassland have different hydrology and histories; one universal fire or grazing prescription is unsafe.

Q13. Examine why India's mineral-industrial geography still carries the imprint of the peninsular shield.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (158 words; practice model, not official): The peninsular shield and its Gondwana basins supplied the ore and coal combinations around which steel, thermal power and rail-linked industry clustered, so the historic mineral heartland continues to shape industrial location. The standard world belts are the Persian Gulf hydrocarbon province, the Appalachian and interior United States belts, the Ruhr-Lorraine coal-iron core, the Russian and Siberian basins, the Chinese northern and interior coal belts, the African Copperbelt and South African shield, the Australian shield and basins, and the Andean and Latin American shield zones. Khullar treats the Chota Nagpur Plateau complex and the wider peninsular shield as India's classic mineral heartland and heavy-industry base. Iron ore belongs to Odisha-Jharkhand, Bailadila and Ballari-Hospet; Gondwana coal to the Damodar, Mahanadi, Son and Godavari valley basins; copper to Khetri, Singhbhum and Malanjkhand; and lead-zinc to Zawar and Rampura-Agucha. Coalfields of the Damodar valley and the adjoining eastern belt pulled steel plants, thermal power and rail-linked heavy industry into east-central India.

Q14. Assess the argument that tribal communities in India should be aggregated for rights and disaggregated for policy design.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (176 words; practice model, not official): Aggregation is defensible for entitlement, portability and atrocity protection and destructive for diagnosis, because vulnerability inside the category ranges from urbanised tribal workers to Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups. The Ministry of Tribal Affairs state-wise list dated 9 July 2024 identifies 75 Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups in 18 States and the Union Territory of Andaman and Nicobar Islands, with legacy criteria including pre-agricultural level of technology, low literacy, stagnant or declining population and subsistence economy. Fifth Schedule mainland tribal-majority regions and Sixth Schedule areas in parts of the North-East have distinct constitutional governance arrangements whose doctrinal detail belongs to Polity and is cross-linked rather than restated in a Society answer. A single legal category is necessary for entitlement, portability and atrocity protection and damaging for diagnosis, because forest-dependent, settled-cultivator and urbanised tribal workers need different livelihood design. Scheduled Tribes were about 8.6 per cent of India's population at Census 2011, and distinct tribal languages including Halbi, Ho and Kui are routed in this documented own Prelims record, which grounds both the scale and the diversity arguments.

Q15. Assess how technology and migration are redistributing care, authority and socialisation within Indian families.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (206 words; practice model, not official): Family change is a redistribution of functions across household, kin, market and digital systems rather than institutional decline, and its outcome depends on space, gender norms, adult mediation and negotiated obligation. Work from home changes the work-home boundary, adding presence, flexible care and reduced commuting while blurring work-care limits and reproducing unequal domestic labour, so the outcome depends on housing space, control over time and gender norms. Mobile-phone use changes child socialisation by displacing some direct interaction while adding mediated learning and contact, so the effect depends on what interaction is displaced, the child's age and context, and whether adult mediation

is present. Urban migration of young, skilled and unmarried women for work expands independent income, mobility and partner choice while creating friction with family expectations of control over marriage timing and choice, and ties are usually renegotiated rather than severed. Urban migration for employment and housing cost separate a nuclear unit from the ancestral household, while remittance and participation in family rituals continue, so form changes before function and later generations weaken the tie further. The family remains the primary institution transmitting caste, religious and gender norms across generations, which makes it the site where broader social change or resistance to it first becomes visible.

Q16. Was the Revolt of 1857 a sepoy mutiny or a popular rebellion?

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (135 words; practice model, not official): It was military in origin, regionally popular in development and not a modern all-India national movement. The main revolt began at Meerut on 10 May 1857 and the sepoys then moved to Delhi. Bahadur Shah Zafar became the symbolic emperor at Delhi, while Bakht Khan was associated with rebel command. Nana Saheb, Tantia Tope and Azimullah Khan are associated with the Kanpur centre. Begum Hazrat Mahal became a major political leader of resistance in Awadh. British settlement displaced Awadh taluqdars before the revolt, and the post-revolt state restored their authority to secure collaboration. The revolt concentrated in north and central India while south India, much of Punjab and many western regions did not join. The most defensible description is a sepoy mutiny in origin that became a wider civil and popular revolt in several regions.

Q17. Assess the Eka movement and the Malabar rebellion as evidence of popular initiative beyond the Congress programme.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (141 words; practice model, not official): Both show local agrarian mobilisation adopting the moral vocabulary of the national movement while developing leadership and trajectories independent of Congress-Khilafat discipline, with Malabar's later communal turn qualifying any simple nationalist reading. The Eka, or unity, movement in the United Provinces protested rent generally fifty per cent above the recorded rent, the oppression of thekedars, and share-rents, developing its own leadership under Madari Pasi and other leaders who did not accept Congress-Khilafat non-violent discipline. Eka included many small zamindars alongside tenants and was suppressed by severe official repression by March 1922, marking its autonomy from Congress control. The Mappila rebellion in Malabar from August 1921 grew from grievances over tenure security, renewal fees and high rents, gaining early impetus from the Malabar District Congress Conference at Manjeri in April 1920, but later acquired a communal character that damaged the Khilafat-Congress alliance.

Q18. Examine how the legacy of the national movement shaped the institutions and values of the Indian republic.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (214 words; practice model, not official): India's democratic survival is best explained by institutional residue rather than by individual virtue: a movement that had already practised elections, argument and organisation for three decades supplied the legitimacy that a new and desperately poor state could not have manufactured for itself. Against the economic liabilities stands a political asset: a tested all-India leadership including Nehru, Patel, Rajendra Prasad, Maulana Azad and Rajagopalachari, a party organised in every province, and settled commitments to democracy, civil liberties, secularism and social reform. The republic did not widen the colonial franchise by degrees but replaced it outright with universal adult franchise, which is the sharpest single contrast available between a colonial liability and a republican choice and the fact that best answers a consolidation question. The colonial state was basically authoritarian and autocratic yet carried liberal fragments such as the rule of law, a relatively independent judiciary and limited press freedoms, and the republic inherited that apparatus of services, police, codes and district administration and had to convert an instrument of order into an instrument of development. The Constitution was adopted on 26 November 1949 and came into force on 26 January 1950, so independence in 1947 and the republic in 1950 are two different constitutional events that must never be merged into a single date.

Q19. Assess Fatehpur Sikri as a planned imperial city rather than merely a monument cluster.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (178 words; practice model, not official): Fatehpur Sikri should be read as a planned imperial city because its significance lies in spatial organisation, not in one famous gateway alone. Built by Akbar and used as capital from 1571 to 1585, the complex joins administrative, residential, religious and service functions within one designed environment. UNESCO's brief highlights the city's roads, water-management system and the central placement of the administrative block, royal palaces and Jama Masjid. This planning can be seen in the internal variety of structures. Diwan-i-Am and Diwan-i-Khas organise political audience. Panch Mahal and the palace zones reflect courtly and domestic use. The Jama Masjid and the white-marble tomb of Sheikh Salim Chishti connect imperial space to devotion and pilgrimage. Buland Darwaza turns victory memory into urban theatre. Even the Ibadat Khana shows that architecture hosted political-religious experimentation, though the full doctrine of Sulh-i-Kul and Din-i-Ilahi belongs to another topic. Therefore Fatehpur Sikri is not best answered as a set of isolated monuments. It is an imperial urban statement in red sandstone where power, piety, ceremony and service are held together by planned space.

Q20. How did Vienna postpone rather than solve the national question?

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (139 words; practice model, not official): Its German, Italian, Polish and Belgian arrangements subordinated nations to dynastic strategy, producing later revision in 1830, 1848 and the unifications. Belgium and Holland were joined in the Kingdom of the Netherlands as a northern buffer against France, an arrangement broken by Belgian independence in 1830. Vienna created a German Confederation of thirty-nine states under Austrian influence, postponing rather than solving German unity. Austria received Lombardy and Venetia and influenced much of divided Italy, while Sardinia-Piedmont gained Genoa and later led unification. Most of the Duchy of Warsaw passed under Russian control as Congress Poland, subordinating Polish national aspirations to great-power bargaining. The Concert accepted Belgian independence in 1830, demonstrating selective adaptation rather than rigid restoration. The revolutions of 1848 exposed the settlement's unresolved liberal, national and social questions, though divided coalitions and loyal dynastic armies helped defeat them.

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS